

The Goldman Sachs Cover Letter Playbook

Built from Sam Leong's (Tracker Academy) framework — decoded, then aimed at Goldman

0. Read this first — the mindset

Sam's single most important framing for cover letters:

The CV explains **what** you did. The cover letter explains **why** — it fills the gaps *between* your experiences and tells a story. It is a **motivation letter**, not a highlight reel.

Two consequences follow from that, and everything else is downstream:

1. **Don't re-flex your achievements.** That's the CV's job. The letter's job is to make the reader believe your path *led* here on purpose.
2. **The cover letter rarely wins you the job — but a bad one can lose it.** It's mostly a tick-box. So the goal is: *don't get flagged*, and where possible, *quietly put yourself ahead of the 90% who wrote a generic one*.

The one lever that reliably moves you ahead of that 90%, per Sam: **referencing a genuine interaction with the firm**. You have exactly that — the insight days. That is the whole reason this letter can be strong.

1. Sam's two structures — and which one you should use

Structure A — The safe default: *Why the company / Why the role / Why you*

Three paragraphs. Use when you have **no real connection** to the firm and it's a volume application. - **Why the company** — the *only* paragraph you truly customise per firm. This is where an *interaction* goes. - **Why the role** — reusable for generic roles; for niche roles, prove you understand it. - **Why you** — least important. Sam is blunt: "this paragraph really doesn't matter." Don't make a mistake here, don't stress.

Structure B — The bespoke story (what Sam used for Optiver)

Ditch the three-paragraph format entirely. Just tell a story. Use this **only when you have a genuine, slightly-unusual connection to the firm**.

Sam's rule: "*If you've had a bit of contact — say two contact points with a company, and any of them are unusual (not just an HR talk) — consider doing this.*"

You qualify for Structure B. You've done Goldman insight days. That is a real interaction, and if you spoke with people there, that's a second, more unusual contact point. Insight-day + a named conversation = exactly the profile Sam says should abandon the safe structure and tell a story.

Recommendation: We build a Structure B letter for Goldman, anchored on the insight day(s). It's higher-ceiling, and you've earned the right to use it.

2. Deconstructing Sam's Optiver letter — line by line

This is the part you asked me to really study: *how he used what the firm cares about and tied it to himself*. Here is every move he makes and **what each one is secretly doing**.

¶1 — **the hook**. *"My journey to Optiver was unconventional; prior to joining in May, I undertook 5 formative internships across investment banking, private equity, and accounting..."* - **Move**: Sentence one lands his single strongest differentiator — *he already worked there*. No warm-up, no "I am writing to apply for...". The most impressive fact goes first because the reader skims. - **For you**: Your sentence one lands *the insight day* — your genuine connection — before anything else.

¶2 — **speak the firm's language**. *"Bayesian probability has always been more than just a university module to me... assigning probabilities to outcomes and identifying maximum-EV decisions in all facets of life. I once believed this perspective to be uniquely my own, until I walked through Optiver's revolving doors and quickly learned that it's precisely the mutual cognitive foundation that the company is defined by."* - **Move**: He mirrors the firm's own culture and vocabulary ("maximum-EV", "Bayesian") and frames it as something he already lived — then reveals it's *the company's cognitive DNA*. This is "what the firm cares about, tied to me" in its purest form. He isn't saying "I value X"; he's saying "the way I already think **is** the way you think." - **For you**: We identify what Goldman actually prizes (below) and show that Janak *already operates that way* — evidenced from the insight days and your own experiences.

¶3 — **the like/dislike storytelling engine**. *"As my first exposure to public markets, I appreciated the inherently objective, Bayesian nature of the work that remains absent in private equity. Whilst trading was enjoyable and intellectually demanding, the skillset of an equity analyst aligns much closer to my skills... offering the perfect blend between the competitive, logical public markets and the analytical, business-focused field of corporate finance."* - **Move**: This is Sam's core cover-letter mechanic. **Liked X (shared with the target role) → the thing I lacked/disliked (absent from the target role) → therefore this role is the perfect blend**. The target role always comes out as the resolution of the story. - **For you**: We build Janak's path as a sequence of "liked this, was missing that → led me here," terminating in Goldman as the synthesis.

¶4 — **the named conversation + proof of understanding**. *"I spoke with Conor Cashman (Equity Analyst, Optiver), who reinforced my initial impressions... equity analysts devote significant time to the intricacies of company financials and fundamental analysis, while... they apply probabilistic frameworks to assess the likelihood of events and the expectation of vol impact."* - **Move**: Two things at once. (1) A **specific named person** he spoke to — instant credibility, un-fakeable, and it's a *second* interaction. (2) He then describes the role in a way *only someone who actually spoke to the team would know* — demonstrating understanding **implicitly** (same principle as CV bullets: show, don't claim). - **For you**: This is where your insight-day conversations become gold. "I spoke with [name], [role, Goldman]..." followed by a genuinely non-obvious observation about the division/firm.

¶5 + **close — warm, confident, low-key**. *"Optiver was by far my favourite internship, and I would treasure the opportunity to return..."* then a clean sign-off. - **Move**: Ends on sincere enthusiasm, no grovelling, no restating the CV.

The skeleton underneath the Optiver letter: 1. Hook = strongest real connection, sentence one. 2. Mirror the firm's cognitive/cultural DNA and show you already share it. 3. Run the like/dislike engine to make the role the inevitable destination. 4. Name-drop a real conversation + prove understanding implicitly. 5. Warm close.

That is the exact skeleton we'll fill for Goldman.

3. What Goldman actually cares about (the non-generic version)

Sam's warning: **never do the generic values dump** ("your value is integrity and I too have integrity"; "your ESG commitment inspires me"). Everyone writes that; it makes you invisible. Instead, use the *real* cultural signals Goldman prizes — and tie them to lived evidence.

Goldman's genuine cultural signals (what to mirror, *implicitly*): - **Commercial instinct / clients-first**. GS Business Principle #1 is literally "Our clients' interests always come first." Referencing this works *only* if attached to a real observation, never quoted cold. - **"One firm" collaboration**. Goldman sells itself as intensely team-based and cross-divisional; excellence is collective, not lone-wolf. - **Intellectual rigour + curiosity**. Precision, getting the details right, being genuinely interested in *why* markets/companies move. - **Early responsibility & apprenticeship**. Juniors given real ownership; a strong feedback/mentorship culture. - **Meritocracy & drive**. High bar, high pace, people who push themselves.

How we use these: we don't *list* them. We pick the one or two that your insight-day experience genuinely surfaced ("what struck me at the insight day was..."), and we show Janak already embodies them via a specific memory or experience. Mirror, don't flatter.

4. The Goldman-specific constraint: one letter, many roles

You told me the letter must **not** describe a single role, because Goldman reuses one application/cover letter across multiple divisions. That fits Sam's model perfectly:

- Keep the letter at the **firm + candidate-story level**, not the role level. (Sam: "why the company" is the section that matters and travels; "why the role" stays broad unless the role is niche.)
- Anchor the "why" on themes **common across Goldman divisions** — analytical rigour, commercial/client thinking, markets curiosity, collaboration — so it reads equally well to an Investment Banking, Global Banking & Markets, or Asset & Wealth Management reviewer.
- The *interaction* (insight day) and *your story* are division-agnostic, which is exactly why Structure B works here.

So the letter's engine is: **your journey** → **what the insight day confirmed** → **why Goldman specifically is the synthesis** — with zero dependence on a single desk.

5. The build plan — what turns this into a finished letter

To write the real thing at Sam's standard, I need to mine three sources. Here's the extraction map:

From your CV / profile (please send): - University, degree, graduation year, grade — for the header + the story spine. - Your experiences in order — so we can build the like/dislike engine ("I did X, liked A, was missing B → led to Y → Goldman is the blend"). - Full name, address, phone, email — for the letter header (formatted like a real letter, see §6).

From the insight-day transcripts (you're sending these): - **Which** Goldman insight day(s), and roughly when — the hook. - **Names + roles** of anyone you spoke to or heard from — the "I spoke with [name]" move (Sam's highest-value line). - **Specific, non-obvious things you genuinely learned** about the firm, a division, or the culture — the "demonstrate understanding implicitly" material and the "mirror their DNA" material. - Any moment that genuinely shifted or confirmed your motivation — the emotional turn of the story.

From you directly (a few questions once I've read the above): - Which divisions you're actually applying to (so I calibrate how broad to keep it). - Is there a *second* contact point (a networking call, an employee you kept in touch with, an alumnus)? Even one unusual one strengthens Structure B.

6. Formatting checklist (Sam's rules for the letter itself)

- Lay it out like a **real letter**: **your address top-right, company address top-left**, then the **date**.
 - Goldman London address (Plumtree Court): *Goldman Sachs, Plumtree Court, 25 Shoe Lane, London EC4A 4AU, United Kingdom.*
 - Salutation: "**Dear Sir/Madam,**" — sign off "**Yours faithfully,**" (faithfully pairs with Sir/Madam; "sincerely" only if you name a person).
 - Abbreviate months to three letters where dates appear.
 - No colour, no hyperlinks left blue, no images.
 - One page. Tight. No filler. Every sentence earns its place.
 - **Zero typos or mis-capitalisations** — Sam's non-negotiable; a single one flags you.
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7. Draft skeleton (placeholders — we fill from the transcripts + your CV)

This is the shape, not the final copy. The bracketed parts get replaced with your real details once I have the CV and insight-day transcripts.

¶1 — **Hook (the insight day, sentence one):** "My introduction to Goldman Sachs came not through a job posting but through [the [name] insight day in [month/year]], where [the specific thing that struck you]..."

¶2 — **Mirror Goldman's DNA + show you already share it:** "[The trait the insight day surfaced — e.g. the way decisions were pressure-tested collaboratively / the client-first instinct] was not new to me — [short evidence that Janak already thinks/works this way]..."

¶3 — **The like/dislike engine (your journey → Goldman as the synthesis):** "[Experience 1] taught me I [liked A]... but [lacked B]. [Experience 2] gave me [B] and confirmed [what you're really drawn to]. Goldman sits precisely at the intersection of [the two threads]..."

¶4 — **Named conversation + implicit proof of understanding:** "I spoke with [Name] ([role], Goldman Sachs), who [reinforced/reframed] [specific, non-obvious insight about the division/firm]..."

¶5 + **close:** "[Why Goldman specifically is the place to do this], and I would value the opportunity to [contribute / begin my career] there. Thank you for your time and consideration."

Next step

Send me **(a) your CV / profile** and **(b) the insight-day transcripts**, and I'll write the full Structure-B letter to this standard, plus a couple of alternative openings so you can pick the strongest hook.